Recommend Her

PREPARING FOR YOUR NEXT CAREER LEAP

A CHECKLIST FOR WOMEN READY FOR LEADERSHIP

"When women recommend women, incredible things happen."

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1. INTRODUCTION: Why Preparation Matters

You're ready for more. You can feel it.

You've delivered results, led teams, solved problems, and grown consistently. But something holds you back—not lack of ability, but lack of *preparation for visibility.*

> **The truth is this: Opportunity favors the prepared.**

When a sponsor asks, "Do you know someone for this role?"—your name should roll off their tongue. But that only happens if you've done the work to be ready. Your CV polished. Your story clear. Your goals defined. Your network activated.

This checklist is your companion for that work. It's designed to move you from *hoping* for an opportunity to being *ready* when it comes.

Because it will come. And when it does, you'll be prepared.

2. HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

This is not a one-time exercise. It's a living document you'll return to throughout your career journey.

Instructions:

- Work through each phase in order
- Check off items as you complete them
- Note dates and reflections in the space provided
- Return to relevant sections before interviews, reviews, or networking events
- Share your progress with a mentor or sponsor who can support you

Timeline: Depending on your current position, completing this checklist thoroughly may take 2-4 weeks. That's okay. Preparation is an investment, not a race.

3. PHASE 1: SELF-ASSESSMENT & CLARITY

Before you can be recommended, you must know what you're recommending yourself for.

3.1 Define Your North Star

Question	Your Answer
What kind of leader do I want to become?	
What problems do I most want to solve?	
What type of organization/culture brings out my best?	
What are my non-negotiables?	
Where do I see myself in 3-5 years?	

3.2 Identify Your Target Roles

☐ I have identified 3-5 specific roles or types of roles I'm targeting

- [ ] I understand the typical requirements for these roles
- [ ] I have researched professionals currently in these roles
- [ ] I can articulate why I'm suited for these roles

Role Target 1:

Role Target 2:

Role Target 3:

3.3 Clarify Your Value Proposition

Complete this sentence: *"I help [who] achieve [what] by [how]."*

Example: "I help technology companies achieve market expansion by leading cross-functional teams through complex product launches."

Your Value Proposition:

4. PHASE 2: READINESS CHECK

Be honest with yourself. Where are you strong? Where do you need growth?

4.1 Skills & Competencies Assessment

Area	Strength	Needs Development	Action Plan
Strategic Thinking	☐	☐	

People Leadership	☐	☐	
Financial Acumen	☐	☐	
Communication/Presentation	☐	☐	
Negotiation	☐	☐	
Industry Knowledge	☐	☐	
Technical Skills	☐	☐	
Change Management	☐	☐	
Stakeholder Influence	☐	☐	

4.2 Experience Gaps

- ☐ I have reviewed job descriptions for my target roles
- ☐ I have identified any common requirements I don't yet meet
- ☐ I have a plan to address these gaps (training, projects, exposure)

My Top 3 Development Priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

5. PHASE 3: VISIBILITY BUILDING

Talent that isn't seen can't be recommended. Visibility is not vanity—it's strategy.

5.1 Internal Visibility (Within Your Current Organization)

- [ ] I have scheduled regular check-ins with my manager about my career aspirations
- [ ] I have identified and volunteered for at least one high-visibility project
- [ ] I have presented my work to senior leaders
- [ ] I have joined or led a cross-functional committee or initiative
- [ ] I have mentored or sponsored someone else
- [ ] My achievements are known beyond my immediate team

5.2 External Visibility (Industry & Professional Community)

- [ ] I have updated my LinkedIn profile (see Phase 6)
- [ ] I am posting or engaging with relevant content in my field
- [ ] I have attended at least one industry event in the past 6 months
- [ ] I have spoken at a conference, panel, or webinar (or have one planned)
- [ ] I have written or contributed to an article, blog, or publication
- [ ] I have joined relevant professional associations or groups

5.3 Personal Brand Statement

Write a 2-3 sentence statement that captures who you are professionally:

_____

_____

_____

6. PHASE 4: NETWORK ACTIVATION

Your network is not just who you know—it's who knows *you* and what you're ready for.

6.1 Map Your Network

Category	Who's in It?	Last Contact	Next Action
Mentors			

Sponsors (actual or potential)			
Peers who've recently advanced			
Industry connections			
Alumni network			
Recommend Her sponsors			

6.2 Network Activation Actions

- [ ] I have identified 5 people who should know what I'm seeking next
- [ ] I have scheduled coffee chats (virtual or in-person) with them
- [ ] I have clearly communicated my career aspirations to my network
- [ ] I have asked for specific introductions
- [ ] I have offered value to my network in return
- [ ] I have followed up and stayed in touch

> **The "Ask" Template**
>
> "Hi [Name], I hope you're well. I'm reaching out because I'm exploring my next career step and would value your perspective. I'm targeting [type of role/industry] and would love to hear your thoughts on [specific question]. If you know anyone else I should connect with, I'd be grateful for an introduction. Thank you for your time!"

7. PHASE 5: DOCUMENT PREPARATION

Your documents are your ambassadors. They must work when you're not in the room.

7.1 CV/Resume

- [ ] My CV follows the**Sponsor-Ready Format**(see our CV Guide)
- [ ] It includes metrics and impact, not just duties

- [ ] It tells a coherent story of my career progression
- [ ] It highlights leadership and initiative beyond my job description
- [ ] It is tailored to my target roles
- [ ] It is 2 pages maximum (1 if early career)
- [ ] It has been reviewed by at least one trusted advisor
- [ ] It is saved as PDF: `FirstName_LastName_CV.pdf`

7.2 LinkedIn Profile

- [ ] My headline goes beyond my job title (e.g., "Marketing Leader | Brand Strategist | Driving Growth")
- [ ] My "About" section tells my story and includes my value proposition
- [ ] My experience section includes achievements, not just responsibilities
- [ ] I have at least one strong recommendation
- [ ] I engage with content relevant to my field
- [ ] My profile is complete and professional

7.3 Elevator Pitch

Prepare a 30-60 second introduction that covers: Who you are, What you do, What you're known for, What you're seeking next.

_____

_____

_____

_____

Practice until it feels natural, not rehearsed.

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8. PHASE 6: APPLICATION & INTERVIEW READINESS

When opportunity knocks, you must be ready to answer—immediately.

8.1 Application Materials

- [ ] I have a tailored CV for each target role type

- [ ] I have a cover letter template I can customize quickly
- [ ] I have a portfolio or work samples (if relevant to my field)
- [ ] I have a list of references with updated contact information
- [ ] I have asked permission from each reference

8.2 Interview Preparation

- [ ] I have researched common interview questions for my target level
- [ ] I have prepared STAR stories (Situation, Task, Action, Result) for:
  - [ ] A time I led through challenge
  - [ ] A time I influenced without authority
  - [ ] A time I drove results
  - [ ] A time I developed others
  - [ ] A time I failed and learned
- [ ] I have practiced my stories out loud
- [ ] I have done at least one mock interview
- [ ] I have prepared thoughtful questions for interviewers

8.3 STAR Story Template

Element	Your Story
Situation: What was happening?	
Task: What needed to be done?	
Action: What did you specifically do?	
Result: What was the outcome? (with metrics)	

9. PHASE 7: MINDSET & RESILIENCE

Your mindset is your greatest asset—or your biggest barrier.

9.1 Internal Barriers Check

- [ ] I have identified any limiting beliefs holding me back
- [ ] I am actively working to reframe these beliefs
- [ ] I have a practice that supports my confidence (journaling, affirmations, therapy, coaching)
- [ ] I have a support system for challenging moments

Common Limiting Beliefs & Reframes

Limiting Belief	Empowered Reframe
I'm not ready yet	I have what it takes to grow into the role
I don't have all the qualifications	No one has all of them; I have the most relevant ones
They won't take me seriously	I will show them what I'm capable of
I'll be seen as pushy	I'll be seen as confident and clear

9.2 Resilience Toolkit

Identify what sustains you during challenging times:

Who can I call when I need encouragement?

What activity restores my energy?

What affirmation or truth do I need to remember?

What has helped me overcome past challenges?

10. YOUR CAREER LEAP ACTION PLAN

Now, turn your insights into action.

My Top 3 Priorities for the Next 30 Days:

1. _____ By when: _____
2. _____ By when: _____
3. _____ By when: _____

My Top 3 Priorities for the Next 90 Days:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Who Will Hold Me Accountable?

Name: _____ Relationship: _____

Check-in frequency: ☐ Weekly ☐ Bi-weekly ☐ Monthly

My Commitment to Myself

I commit to investing in my own readiness. I will not wait for permission. I will prepare, act, and trust that my moment is coming—and when it does, I'll be ready.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

11. JOIN THE TALENT POOL

You've done the preparation work. Now it's time to be seen.

Your next step:

✅ Complete this checklist

✅ Update your CV using our **CV Optimization Guide**

✅ Submit your profile to the **Recommend Her Talent Pool**

✅ Get connected with sponsors ready to recommend you

www.recommendher.africa/talent

#RecommendHer #ReadyForLeadership #CareerLeap #WomenInLeadership

BONUS: QUICK REFERENCE CHECKLIST

Print this page and keep it visible.

Monthly Readiness Check:

- [ ] I have updated my CV with any new achievements
- [ ] I have engaged with my network at least once
- [ ] I have learned or strengthened one skill
- [ ] I have taken one visibility-building action
- [ ] I have checked in with my accountability partner
- [ ] I have reviewed my target roles and adjusted as needed

Weekly Readiness Check (During Active Search):

- [ ] I have applied to at least [X] relevant opportunities
- [ ] I have followed up on previous applications
- [ ] I have had at least one networking conversation
- [ ] I have practiced interview stories
- [ ] I have taken time for mindset and resilience

Recommend Her Movement

Mentor. Recommend. Elevate.

www.recommendher.africa

#RecommendHer #CareerLeap #WomenInLeadership